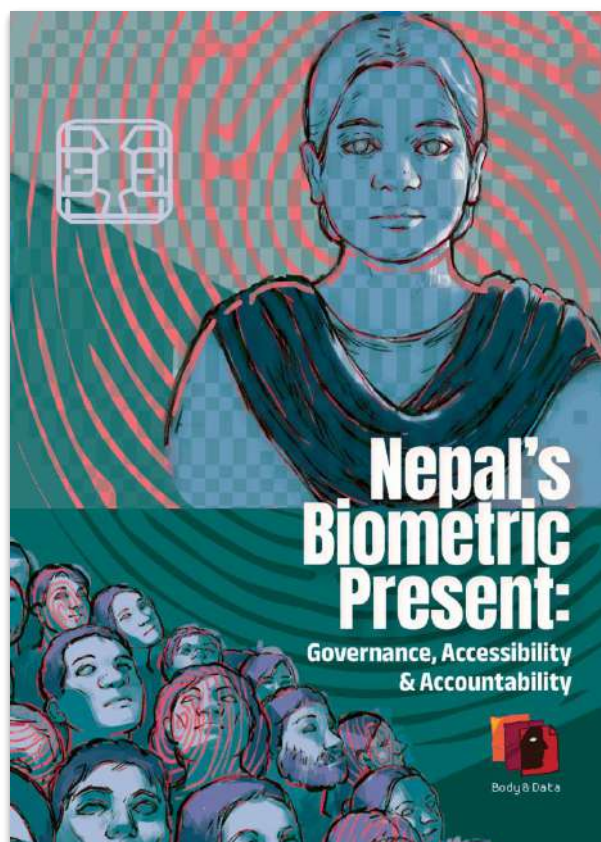


Nepal's Biometric Present: Governance, Accessibility and Accountability



[Pdf Report](#)

[Accessible eBook](#)

[Interactive Report](#)

[handbook](#)

The NID card has been integrated into existing bureaucratic systems, but the shift toward “smart” governance lacks systematic planning and strategic direction. Weak infrastructure, poor connectivity, unequal internet access, and power outages continue to hinder enrollment, disproportionately affecting women, low-income and marginalized groups. Persons with disabilities also face persistent barriers and discriminatory administrative practices despite existing policies.



Nepal's Biometric Present: Governance, Accessibility and Accountability

Interactive Report

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

In November 2018, the Government of Nepal introduced the ‘National ID’ (NID) to provide digital identity to its citizens. The government ambitiously claimed to enroll all residents biometrically by 2023. Each enrolled person would receive a unique 10-digit identification number, which would serve as their National ID. This number would be linked to their biometric data, such as a digital photograph, fingerprints, and iris scans, as well as personal details like name, address, and gender. The NID is an identification process designed for easy online identity verification, but its digital use has been very limited since it started in 2018. [More >](#)



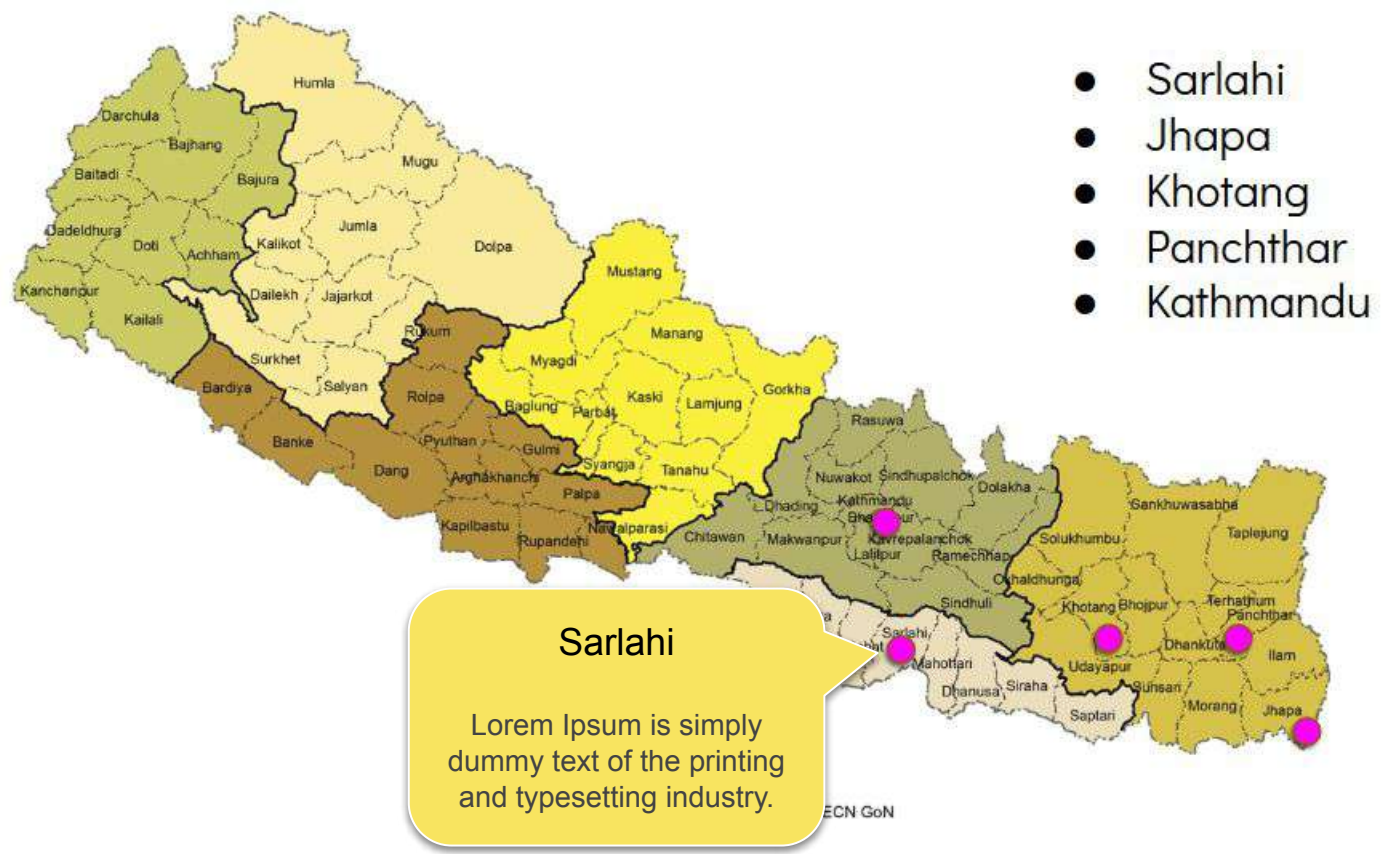
The Birth of National Identity Card



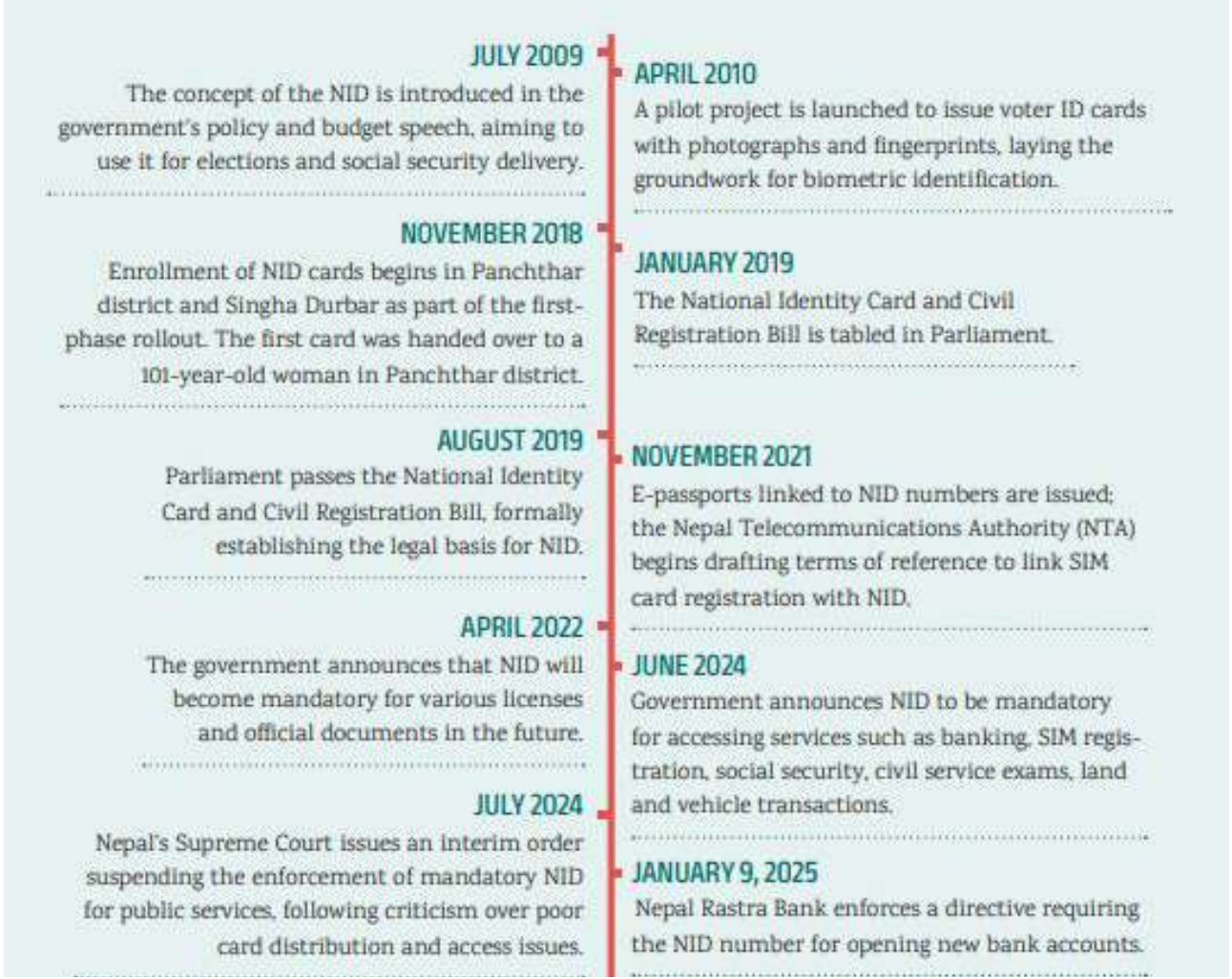
How the Government is Working



Research Areas



NID Timeline





Biometric tools being used today are not just meant to record or standardize people’s physical features, they can also inadvertently make social inequalities worse. For instance, when such technologies fail to account for the diverse backgrounds and lived realities of different groups, they risk excluding significant portions of society. Rather than relying on “one-size-fits-all” designs that risk entrenching unfair treatment and amplifying existing discrimination, biometric systems should be intentionally developed to promote fairness, inclusivity, and equal access for all.

Box 9: Key concerns of the PwDs

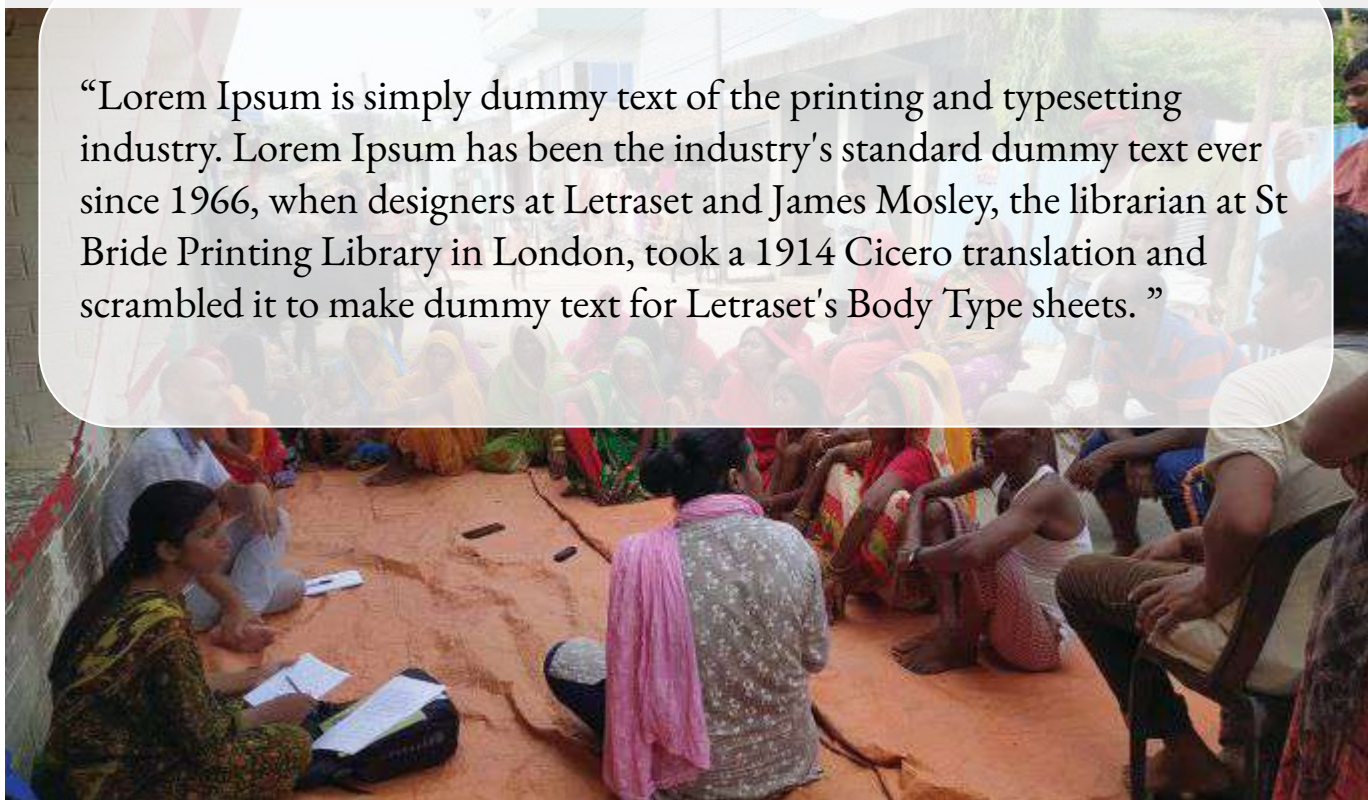
- Provide government officials with proper training and sensitization to better address the needs of PwDs, as there is a serious lack of sensitivity and awareness among government officials when providing fair and equitable services.
- Regularly organize special outreach camps or enrollment drives to make services more accessible to PwDs, as enrollment centers lack alternative accommodation and communication tools.
- Ensure more grievance redressal options for PwDs when they encounter procedural barriers or face enrollment denials, in order to make the enrollment process more inclusive.

Box 10: Key concerns of the queer community

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Way Forward



The focus of this report has been on the processes of designing the NID, its legislative measures, implementation practices, and citizens’ concerns. Body & Data found that Nepal’s National ID program reflects an ambitious effort to improve governance and improve access to public services through digital systems. However, as this report has shown, the process remains deeply flawed in its current form. Weak governance structures, inadequate consultation with stakeholders, insufficient transparency, and fragile digital infrastructure have undermined the program’s stated goals.

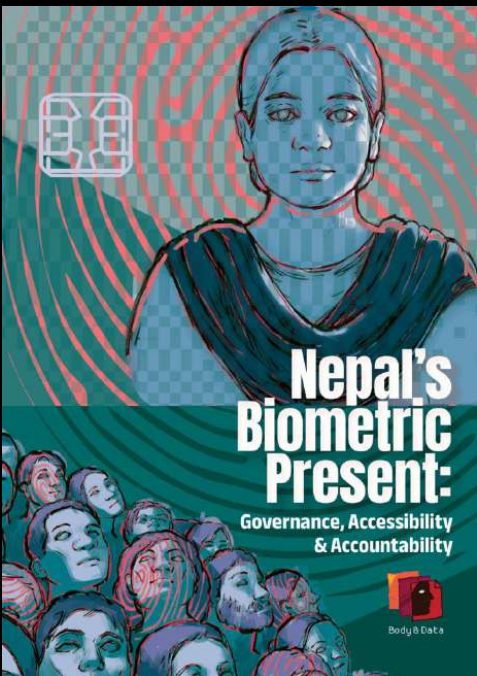
Recommendations for the Government



Recommendations for Private Sector



Recommendations for Civil Society



Pdf Report

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